

A SEASONAL COMPANION TO THE PARENT SERIES

The School Season Toolkit

Seven ready-to-use schedules, checklists, and scripts to help your child (and you) ease into daycare, preschool, or school — printable, practical, and done in minutes.



BEFORE YOU START

About this toolkit

The weeks before a new school year are full of small, practical decisions — when to shift bedtime, what to pack, how to talk about the first goodbye. This toolkit isn't a long read. It's seven short, printable tools you can use this week, built to sit alongside your child's actual countdown to day one.

What's inside

A 14-day gradual return-to-routine schedule, an age-by-age school supplies checklist, a gradual sleep-adjustment schedule, an age-by-age independence-skills schedule, a short section written for you (the parent) before the first day, a last-3-days checklist, and a set of social-skills conversation cards for making new friends.

Pair it with the series

For the fuller picture on separation anxiety, goodbye scripts, and what's realistic by age, this toolkit is designed to sit alongside **Guide 5 — Separation Anxiety & Starting School** (the B.A.S.E. Method) from the Peep & Beyond Parent Series. Big feelings at drop-off or pickup are also covered in **Guide 1 — When Your Child Hits or Loses Their Temper** (the C.A.L.M. Path), and screen-time wind-down in **Guide 2 — Screens & Big Feelings**.

A note before you continue: This toolkit is educational and is not a substitute for medical or mental-health advice. Every child adjusts at their own pace — if you're concerned about your child's adjustment, sleep, or development, please speak with your pediatrician.

CONTENTS

Seven tools, ready to print

01	The Gradual Return Schedule A 14-day plan to ease out of holiday mode	04
02	The School Supplies Checklist By age — what actually matters to pack	05
03	The Sleep-Adjustment Schedule Shifting bedtime without a fight, day by day	06
04	The Independence Skills Schedule By age — small skills that build classroom confidence	07
05	For You, Before the First Day This one's about the parent, not the child	08
06	The Last-3-Days Checklist Print it, tape it up, tick it off	10
07	Social Skills Conversation Cards Simple lines for making a first friend	11

TOOL 01

The Gradual Return Schedule

A sudden jump from unstructured holiday days to a strict school schedule tends to cause resistance and exhaustion. Easing in over two weeks — instead of one hard switch the night before — makes the actual first day noticeably calmer.

DAYS BEFORE DAY ONE	FOCUS	WHAT TO DO
Day 14–11	Notice the baseline	Track current bed/wake times for a few days — this is your true starting point, not the "ideal" one.
Day 10–8	Shift bedtime	Move bedtime 15 minutes earlier every two nights. Keep wake time steady, even on weekends.
Day 7–5	Reintroduce structure	Bring back short focused activities — reading, simple puzzles, quiet table time — 15–20 minutes a day.
Day 4–3	Preview the routine	Walk through the school-morning routine once as a dry run: wake, dress, breakfast, bag, door.
Day 2	Review the schedule together	Look at the new daily schedule together, framed as something exciting to explore, not a rule to obey.
Day 1	End the holiday well	Do one favorite low-key activity together to close out the break on a warm note.

KEEP IN MIND

If you're starting later than 14 days out, compress the same order of steps rather than skipping any — even a shortened version beats an overnight switch.

TOOL 02

The School Supplies Checklist

Shopping for supplies isn't only a logistics task — letting your child choose within limits, and pack their own bag, turns it into genuine emotional preparation. Use this list as a starting point and adjust to your child's school.

Toddler & daycare · 1–3

- ☐ A labeled bag they can carry themselves, even a small one Let them choose the color or character
- ☐ A comfort item approved by the daycare, if allowed
- ☐ A full change of labeled clothes

Preschool · 3–6

- ☐ A backpack sized to fit their own back, not an oversized one They should be able to put it on unassisted
- ☐ An easy-open lunch box and water bottle — practice opening it at home first
- ☐ Named clothing labels for jackets, hats, and shoes

School-age · 6–12

- ☐ Supplies chosen with input from your child within a set budget
- ☐ A simple system for homework and notes — one folder, not five
- ☐ Their own labeled water bottle and any daily essentials they now manage themselves

TOOL 03

The Sleep-Adjustment Schedule

Moving bedtime earlier all at once the night before school rarely works — the body needs time to reset its internal clock. Shifting gradually is the single biggest lever for an easier first week. (This pairs with the fuller sleep science in Guide 3 — Sleep & Bedtime Routines.)

TIMING	BEDTIME SHIFT	SUPPORT IT WITH
Day 1–2	No change yet	Track the actual current bedtime for two nights — write it down.
Day 3–4	15 minutes earlier	Start the wind-down routine 15 minutes earlier too, not just lights-out.
Day 5–6	+15 minutes (30 total)	Hold wake time steady every morning, including weekends.
Day 7–8	+15 minutes (45 total)	Cut screens in the hour before bed — blue light delays natural sleepiness.
Day 9–10	+15 minutes (60 total)	Get morning sunlight right after waking — it resets the body clock faster than anything else.
Day 11–14	Hold the new bedtime	Keep it steady through the final stretch so it's already routine by day one.

RESEARCH NOTE

Sleep-medicine guidance consistently favors small, staged bedtime shifts (10–15 minutes every couple of days) over a single large change — the body’s circadian rhythm adjusts gradually, and abrupt shifts tend to cause more resistance, not less.

TOOL 04

The Independence Skills Schedule

A child who can open their own lunch box or put on their own shoes feels less anxious in the classroom than one who's used to an adult doing it for them. Pick one skill at a time, practice it at home first, and let it be imperfect at first.

Toddler • 1–3

- ☐ Drinking from an open or straw cup without help
- ☐ Pulling pants up and down for toileting attempts
- ☐ Putting toys back in a bin at cleanup time

Preschool • 3–6

- ☐ Putting on shoes and a jacket unassisted Practice at home a few weeks before, not on the first morning
- ☐ Opening their own lunch box and water bottle
- ☐ Washing and drying hands independently

School-age • 6–12

- ☐ Packing their own bag from a simple checklist the night before
- ☐ Waking to an alarm instead of being woken by a parent
- ☐ Speaking up to an adult when they need help or feel unwell

KEEP IN MIND

Praise the attempt, not just a perfect result — "you got your shoes on by yourself" matters more than whether they're on the right feet.

TOOL 05

For You, Before the First Day

Every tool so far has been about your child. This one is about you — because a parent's anxiety about separation tends to travel to the child through tone of voice and body language, even when it's never said out loud.

Name what you're feeling

Worrying about a first big separation doesn't mean you're overprotective — it means you care. Naming the feeling instead of pushing it down (to a partner, a friend, or even a notes app) tends to loosen its grip well before drop-off morning.

Plan for yourself, not just for them

Decide ahead of time what you'll do with the newly quiet hour or morning — a walk, a coffee, work you've been putting off. Having somewhere for your attention to go makes the goodbye easier to walk away from.

RESEARCH NOTE

Attachment research (building on Mary Ainsworth's foundational work) shows children read a caregiver's calm as a signal of safety — a steady, confident goodbye communicates more reassurance than any amount of comforting words.

Rehearse a calm goodbye

If the moment feels hard to picture going well, rehearse it once — even just saying the goodbye phrase out loud to a mirror. It sounds small, but a goodbye you've already said once tends to come out steadier the first time it counts.

Find your people

Other parents going through the exact same first-week adjustment are often the fastest source of relief — a quick message to another parent at pickup can do more than any amount of reassurance from someone who isn't living it right now.

A short reminder to keep close this week

Your child borrows their sense of safety from your calm — not from the absence of your worry, but from how steadily you carry it. Taking care of your own nerves this week is part of taking care of theirs. It isn't a side task; it's the job.

FOR THE FULLER GOODBYE SCRIPT

See Guide 5 — Separation Anxiety & Starting School for the full B.A.S.E. Method, age-by-age expectations, and a complete table of ready-to-say goodbye scripts.

TOOL 06

The Last-3-Days Checklist

The final stretch before day one can either lower anxiety or spike it, depending on how it's used. Print this page and tick items off as you go.

3 days before

- ☐ New bedtime is already in effect — not starting tonight
- ☐ Bag and outfit are laid out the night before, every night from here on

2 days before

- ☐ Do a full morning-routine dry run: wake, dress, eat, bag, door
- ☐ Swap any threats ("you'll be tired if...") for encouraging language

1 day before

- ☐ Open a calm, unhurried moment before bed to hear any worries out loud — without minimizing them
- ☐ Say the goodbye plan out loud together, so tomorrow's goodbye isn't a surprise

AVOID THIS TRAP

Don't let the final days fill up with warnings and countdown pressure — a calm, steady routine in the last 72 hours does more for confidence than any last-minute pep talk.

TOOL 07

Social Skills Conversation Cards

Worrying about making friends is one of the most common first-week anxieties. Practicing a few simple opening lines at home — out loud, even a little playfully — gives your child something concrete to reach for in the moment.

"Can I play with you?"

The simplest, most direct opener — works for almost any group activity.

"My name is _____. What's yours?"

A friendly, low-pressure way to start any first conversation.

"That looks fun — what are you making?"

Shows genuine interest and opens the door without asking to join outright.

"Do you want to sit here?"

A small, welcoming offer your child can make to someone else who looks unsure too.

"I don't know anyone yet either."

Reminds them they're not the only one starting fresh — a quiet bit of solidarity.

"See you tomorrow!"

A small, confident close that makes the next day feel like it's already planned.

KEEP IN MIND

Friendships take time to form — the goal for week one isn't a best friend, it's a child who's willing to try. Notice and praise the attempt, not the outcome.

WHERE THIS TOOLKIT CAME FROM

Sources & continuing the series

American Academy of Sleep Medicine (AASM) staged bedtime-adjustment guidance. American Academy of Pediatrics / HealthyChildren.org on school readiness and separation. Mary Ainsworth's foundational attachment research on caregiver calm and secure separation. Sleep Foundation guidance on circadian-rhythm adjustment and morning light exposure.

GO DEEPER WITH THE SERIES

Guide 5 — Separation Anxiety & Starting School (the B.A.S.E. Method) covers the full goodbye script, age-by-age expectations, and when to seek extra support. **Guide 3 — Sleep & Bedtime Routines** (the R.E.S.T. Method) covers the deeper sleep science behind Tool 03. **Guide 1 — When Your Child Hits or Loses Their Temper** (the C.A.L.M. Path) is there for the big-feelings moments that don't stay neatly inside a schedule.

You've got this, one small step at a time.

— Peep & Beyond